

COMP 3700A: Contributing to Open Source

Exploring FOSS communities

Charlotte Curtis

September 16, 2026

Housekeeping

- Do we have notetakers for [today's topics](#)?
 - Goal is to have the PR for each topic submitted within **1 week**
 - You should now be able to see start/target dates!
 - After submission, I will add a reviewer
- You should have all received an invitation to join as an "Outside Collaborator"

Today's Goals

- Look at the projects you shared for [homework](#):
 - Common documents
 - Project activity
 - Communication channels
- Understand the various roles in FOSS communities

I will use [Inkscape](#) and [QBittorrent](#) as examples. Please pick 1-2 others to look at and answer questions during this class.

Common (non-code) Documents

While there are no real "rules" to open source, most repos will contain:

- README
- LICENSE
- CONTRIBUTING
- INSTALL
- Maybe AGENTS, CODE_OF_CONDUCT, CODING_STYLE, etc

These are often in all-caps titled Markdown files, but neither is guaranteed



What common documents do you see? How do they differ?

Evaluating project activity

- Issues (GitHub) or Work Items (GitLab) are "to do" items
- Pull/merge requests are accomplishing the "to dos"
- Consider:
 - Which items get closed and why
 - Which get lots of comments
 - Age of open items
 - Tags
- What are the official communication channels, and how often do people post?

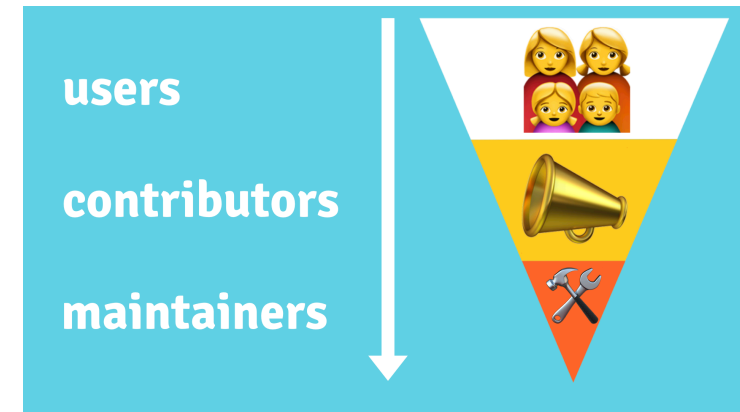


How active are the projects?

*What communication
channels are most used?*

Roles in FOSS projects

- You are already a **user** — might submit bug report
- This semester, you will become a **contributor**:
 - Reproduce bugs
 - Write code, documentation, translations
 - Someone will review your submission
- **Maintainers** are the project leaders who review and merge PRs, manage releases, etc
- The **bus factor** in FOSS is often very low!





What are the key roles? Who are the people in these roles?

Next up

- Lab exercise: merging the PRs submitted last week
- Monday: special guest lecture on copyright and licensing
- [Homework question](#): read about licensing